JACK OF ALL TRADES

The batting approach was sorted out, but for total cricket to take full shape, the selection and use of multi-dimensional players was the next piece in the puzzle. With a paucity of all-rounders in Indian cricket, the think-tank still found a way to accommodate four multi-dimensional players in its squad of 15. It was by no means an easy task, as some unpopular decisions had to be taken. Shivam Dube's ability to bowl an over or two—although he wasn't called up to bowl in the tournament—meant another in-form middle-order batter, Rinku Singh, missed out. Axar Patel and Ravindra Jadeja—even though they performed similar roles—were both ahead of the potent Kuldeep Yadav in the pecking order to make the playing XI, because of their all-round abilities. Then there was the backing that Hardik Pandya received from the team management in his role as the third seamer despite having a forgettable IPL. No other story epitomises India's gritty turnarounds in this World Cup better than Pandya's 360-degree turn in fortunes.

Once the personnel were identified, their optimum utilisation was the key to favourable results. That's something Dravid and Sharma plotted with immaculate care. The elastic flexibility (just like total football) in India's batting order remained a common theme throughout the tournament. To maximise the team's batting potential, batters were thrown into different situations based on the score, pitch conditions, juncture of the match and the bowlers in operation. In fact, the Indian captain didn't shy away from spelling out his tactics at the beginning of the World Cup. "Only the openers have a fixed batting spot, everyone else needs to be flexible in their batting position and adapt to the situation at hand," he said.

Therefore, throughout the World Cup, it was common to see an Indian batting order with a fluid middle. If you had Axar Patel walk into bat at No. 4 against Pakistan and chip in with a stable 20; the same player walked in to bat at No. 8 in the match with Afghanistan and got a quickfire 12. Hardik Pandya batted No. 5 in the semis and No. 8 in the final. Ravindra Jadeja batted above the power-hitter like Shivam Dube on a dicey pitch in Guyana, while Dube batted two spots above him on a belter of a pitch in Barbados. This flexibility allowed 'total cricket' to be in play: allowing for batters to utilise their strengths based on the conditions while disrupting opposition plans by surprising them with the man sent out in the middle.



GETTY IMAGES

SKY HIGH →
Suryakumar Yadav sprints along the boundary to take a miraculous catch to dismiss David Miller of South Africa in the final over of the T20 Word Cup final in Bridgetown, Barbados, June 29

THE SHOW-STOPPER!

In keeping with its norm-breaking ways in this World Cup, it was the bowling unit that emerged as the stronger part of India's campaign—a clean break from India's batting star-cast landing them trophies. For once, the age-old adage of 'batters win you matches but bowlers win you tournaments' played out to script for Team India.

One could sense the calm amidst the Indian faithful in the stadia every time the bowlers took to the field. In the final versus South Africa, just the knowledge that Jasprit Bumrah and Arshdeep Singh still had three of the last five overs to bowl convinced Suryakumar Yadav that India was still in the game. Even on occasions when one thought that the batting had fallen short of a failsafe total, fans kept faith in Bumrah and Co. to get the team past the finish line. The defence of a measly 119 in the win versus Pakistan in the group stages and the final, where 176 was guarded on a batting-friendly pitch, offer perfect examples. It was a complete role reversal from the past, where Indian batters had to compensate for bowlers' profligacy. Surely, this very confidence in the Indian bowlers would have afforded Indian batsmen the luxury of playing their fearless brand of cricket.

Like the batsmen, the blueprint for the bowlers had a similar shape—roles were defined, but flexibility was the key. Arshdeep, with his swing, was the man to pick wickets with the new ball and curtail runs in the death